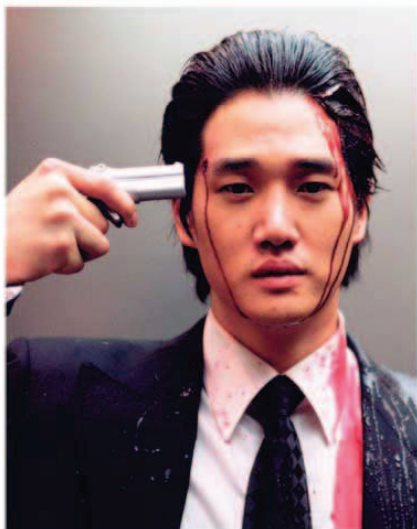




LAUGH AND THE WORLD LAUGHS WITH YOU. WEEP AND YOU WEEP ALONE

OLDBOY / 2003

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Revenge thriller

DIRECTOR

Park Chan-wook

WRITERS

Park Chan-wook, Lim Chun-hyeong, Hwang Jo-yun, Lim Joon-hyung (screenplay); Nobuaki Minegishi (comic); Garon Tsuchiya (story)

STARS

Choi Min-sik, Yu Ji-tae, Kang Hye-jeong

BEFORE

2000 Park's first movie *Joint Security Area* is a thriller set on the border with North Korea.

2002 Park directs *Sympathy for Mr. Vengeance*, the first part of his *Vengeance* trilogy.

AFTER

2009 Park tries his hand at horror with *Thirst*, the story of a priest becoming a vampire after a failed experiment.

Oldboy (2003) is the second entry in the *Vengeance* trilogy by Korean director Park Chan-wook, coming between *Sympathy for Mr. Vengeance* (2002) and *Sympathy for Lady Vengeance* (2005). The fact that *Oldboy* is the only one without "vengeance" in the title is telling, and signifies a difference in focus from the others.

Oldboy is certainly a revenge movie, but it is concerned more with the corroding effect of an obsession than with the catharsis of killing the one who has wronged. The very concept, in which an unassuming loser, Oh Dae-su (Choi Min-sik), is abducted and kept prisoner in a room for 15 years without knowing why, or by whom, is more about torture of the mind than of the

body. This theme intensifies as the movie progresses, with both protagonist and antagonist waging a war of minds with each other in which their motives are defined by suffering, rather than by their urge for violent revenge. In this sense, *Oldboy* is more than a revenge movie. It is an examination of despair. When Oh escapes, he sets out to discover the identity of his captor and avenge himself, only to

A guard restrains Oh Dae-su just as Oh learns the reason for his imprisonment. In a gesture of remorse, he commits a gruesome act of self-harm with a pair of scissors.

